

SALES TRAINING DEBRIEF · SESSION 7

80% Likable. 20% Technical. Always.

Session led by Corie Dawson, Director

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The thesis in one line

Likability is the lever that controls every other lever in a sale. A 100% technical pitch leaves zero room for error — one slip and the deal walks. An 80% likable, 20% technical pitch builds enough connection that the prospect forgives small mistakes, takes your call, and looks for reasons to say yes instead of reasons to say no. Likability is your insurance policy.

"If you're likable, there's a higher chance they'll trust you. If you're not likable, there's more chance they won't. It really is that simple — and it really is that important." — Corie

1. Digest the lesson — don't just chew it

The session opened with a correction on how the team processes coaching. After Thursday's lesson on connection, the reps acknowledged the concept but couldn't explain it clearly when asked. That gap matters: chewing is hearing the concept; digestion is reflecting on it until you can teach it to someone else.

"If you can't explain it to a six-year-old, you don't know it." — Corie (paraphrasing Albert Einstein)

What digestion actually looks like

- Hear the concept in the session (10 minutes).
- Spend 4× that time turning it over (40 minutes) — in the shower, on a walk, between meetings.
- Try to explain it to a colleague or partner without notes. The gaps surface immediately.
- Apply it once on a live call within 48 hours. Reflection without application is decoration.

When you sit down for the next session, the test isn't "did I attend?" It is "could I run yesterday's lesson myself?" If not, you skipped the digestion step.

2. The five ingredients of a relationship

Every relationship — personal, professional, romantic, transactional — is built from five ingredients. Corie compared them to a pasta recipe.

Ingredient	What it is
Time	The flour. The bulk of the dish. Most relationships rely on this as their foundation.
Care	The eggs. What binds everything together. Without care, the rest collapses.
Experiences	The salt. Shared moments — good or bad — that make a relationship distinct.
Sharing ideas	Conversation. Back-and-forth. The texture of the relationship.
Giving	Acts of generosity — physical items, attention, thoughts, or effort.

Why this matters for sales

In a new sales relationship you have zero of ingredient one — time. So you cannot rely on time-built trust to carry the deal. Instead, you have to deliberately overload the other four (care, experiences, sharing ideas, giving) to compensate. A new prospect who has seen real care from you in 30 minutes can feel as connected as a long-term client who has had 18 months of average treatment.

"If you haven't got the flour, you're trying to make pasta out of broccoli. You can do it — but you have to work much harder on the other ingredients." — Corie (paraphrased)

3. Why long relationships decay

A counterintuitive observation: as a relationship gets longer, most people invest less effort, not more. Time becomes a substitute for the other four ingredients. The reasoning runs subconsciously — "I've known them long enough, I can coast a bit."

"The longer someone knows someone, the worse they become — because they offset their time. Time replaces effort. That's human nature. Catching yourself doing it is the high-performance move." — Corie (paraphrased)

The reversal — what high performers do

- They get MORE attentive as time passes, not less.
- They periodically run a self-audit: "How am I treating this person versus when we first met?"
- They use small triggers to inject fresh care — handwritten note, an unexpected gift, an unprompted check-in.
- They treat long-term clients with first-date energy, not 18-month-mortgage energy.

This applies to the team itself, not just to clients. The longer you work alongside the same colleagues, the more likely complacency creeps in. The fix is identical: refresh the care.

4. The three locking mechanisms of every sale

Corie's central model for the session: every sale is a lock with three pins. All three have to release for the deal to open. If any one is stuck, no amount of pressure on the others will close it.

Lock 1 — Affordability

Does the prospect have the money? This is vetted in advance using the affordability formula (Session 2: $\text{service} \times \$100\text{k}$; $\text{trade} \times \$100\text{k} \times 3$). If you walk into a meeting and the math says they can't afford it, you've booked an appointment that was never closeable. Out of your control once the meeting starts.

Lock 2 — Intent

Do they actually want to buy? A prospect can be wealthy and still have zero intent — they're winding down, retiring, switching industries, or just bored and curious. Vet intent early in the meeting with a single question (see Section 9). Out of your control once it's established they don't intend to buy.

Lock 3 — Likability

Do they like you? This is the one mechanism you fully control. And because the first two are binary (either they have it or they don't), the only variable you can actually move is this one. Almost every closing failure where the math worked traces back to a likability gap.

"You can't change whether they have the money. You can't change whether they want to buy. You can change whether they like you. So put your effort there — that's the only lock you can pick." — Corie (paraphrased)

5. Building rapport with a brand-new prospect

Corie used a long analogy comparing rapport-building with a new prospect to building a new relationship outside work. The mechanics are identical — and importantly, the team already knows how to do this in their personal lives. The trick is to translate the same instincts into the sales call.

The principles

1. **Take the pressure off.** A new prospect, like a new acquaintance, knows when you want something from them. The more pressure you transmit, the more they pull away.
2. **Don't go straight for the close.** You wouldn't propose marriage on a first date. You also shouldn't expect a signature on a first call. Build the connection — then the close is barely a step.
3. **Ask, don't guess.** What do they like? What was their last good experience? Where are they trying to go? Real questions about their world produce real answers.

4. **Give space.** Encourage them to think it over before committing — even when you don't want them to. The act of permission resets the dynamic.
5. **Break the script.** Prospects walk into a sales call expecting a salesperson script. Do something they don't expect (don't ask for the close, mention something personal, leave early). Pattern interrupts make people curious — and curious people lean in.

"You give space when you don't have time. Care plus space is what builds new-relationship trust faster than anything else." — How to phrase it

6. Pattern interrupts

When you break a prospect's expected pattern, you trigger curiosity instead of resistance. Most reps default to the predictable salesperson script — and predictable scripts trigger predictable defences.

Examples of useful pattern interrupts

- Ending a meeting before the prospect expected it: "I think we've covered enough — have a think, I'll call Monday." Removes pressure, signals confidence.
- Asking a question they didn't expect: "Just out of interest — what's your favourite part of running this business?" The answer reveals their real motivation.
- Naming the awkward thing first: "Look, I know you've probably had bad experiences with agencies. Let me explain why this isn't one of those calls."
- Refusing the close they offered you: "Honestly, I don't want you to sign anything today. Have a look at what we've discussed first."
- Being slightly self-deprecating: "I'm going to ask you a dumb question — but you'll see why in a second."

The mechanism is the same in all of these: you do something other than what the prospect predicted. That gap forces them to re-process you as a person, not as a script.

7. The three landmines — religion, politics, money

There are three topics that will instantly destroy a new-relationship dynamic if you hit them on the wrong side: religion, politics, and personal finance. The rule: don't step on any of them in a first meeting.

"You're gambling on something you don't need to gamble on. If you hit any of those three on the wrong side, the relationship is over before it started. Hedge."
— Corie (paraphrased)

Why they're landmines

Each of the three is high-conviction territory. People hold strong views, and they form instant judgments about anyone with opposing views. A casual comment that lands on the wrong side will end the relationship before you've done anything else wrong. Even when you agree, the cost of being wrong is so high that the bet isn't worth it.

Soft territory that builds rapport instead

- Their business and their journey (always safe; people love talking about their own success)
- Their work environment and team
- Local landmarks, restaurants, sports teams (neutral, light)
- Pets, kids, holidays — if they raise them first
- What they're trying to build next

8. Asymmetric bets — language that can only help

Some questions and statements have no downside. They build rapport whether the prospect agrees or disagrees. These are asymmetric bets, and they should make up the bulk of your fact-finding language.

The model phrase

■ *“That must be a hard job.” — Corie's go-to line*

If the prospect agrees (“yeah, it's relentless”), they'll unload their challenges — building connection through shared empathy. If they disagree (“no, I love it”), they'll tell you what they love about it — building connection through shared enthusiasm. Either way, you win.

More asymmetric openers

- “How did you end up in this industry?” (everyone loves their origin story)
- “What's the biggest challenge in your business right now?” (vents OR pivots to confidence)
- “What's the best part of your week, usually?” (positive even when they're busy)
- “You've obviously been doing this a while — what's the secret?” (flattering + invites teaching)

Avoid symmetric bets — questions or statements where one answer builds the relationship and the other tanks it. That includes any opinion you state first about a topic the prospect might disagree with.

9. The single line that vets intent fastest

Lock 2 (intent) needs to be checked before you spend significant pitch energy. The single fastest way to surface it:

■ *“If you don't mind me asking — over the next few years, are you looking to scale this up, or are you thinking more about winding it down?” — The vetting question*

How to read the answer

When they say	What you do
"We're looking to scale — really want to grow this."	Pitch hard. Position your service as a growth lever. Everything is open.
"We're going to maintain — happy at this size."	Reposition as maintenance / protection. Don't pitch growth — they'll resist.
"Honestly, we're winding down. Maybe two more years."	Reposition as preparing-to-sell. Website becomes a sale asset. Or graciously step back.
"Not sure yet — depends on the market."	Treat as cautious. Pitch a smaller package with a clear exit. Don't go big.

10. The "speech" — recognising a polite no

When a prospect likes you (lock 3 is open) but can't close (lock 1 or 2 is shut), they'll often deliver what Corie called "the speech" — a long, warm, often weirdly off-topic monologue that goes nowhere near a deal but doesn't feel like rejection.

What the speech sounds like

"You're a really nice guy. You actually remind me of my nephew. I should tell you — I'm taking a cruise next month, and we've got a dog who's having a heart operation, and the neighbour's cat lost its tail and ended up in our yard — anyway, definitely give me a call next year, I really think we should do this..."

What it actually means

Translation: "I like you enough to be polite, but I can't actually buy from you right now." This is good news AND bad news. Good: you successfully opened lock 3 (likability). Bad: you failed to vet lock 1 (affordability) or lock 2 (intent) before the meeting. The lesson is upstream — better qualification before the pitch.

The right response: don't fight it. Don't lower the price. Don't try harder. The locks that need to open simply aren't available. "Thanks so much — I really appreciate it. I'll keep your details and reach out properly when the timing works." Then move on. The likability you built is banked for the future.

11. Likability creates ransom in the buyer's mind

A real-world story from Corie: he needed a new vehicle. The local big-city dealer was condescending, didn't follow up properly, and treated him like an inconvenience. He rang a country dealer 200 km away. That salesperson talked about fishing, mentioned they had a holiday shack near the same bay Corie's family did, joked about the modifications, and never pressured him. Total time spent building rapport: under 15 minutes on the first call.

Corie bought the vehicle from the country dealer. He drove 200 km to pick it up. He bought his second vehicle from the same dealer, even when the city dealer offered better prices. He explained to the country dealer, when finally moving to a third vehicle via someone else: "It's not that you weren't the best option — it's that I had personal circumstances that forced my hand. I'm sorry."

What this story illustrates

- Likability creates a kind of buyer-side ransom — the prospect feels they HAVE to buy from you, even when alternatives are cheaper or more convenient.
- Connection compresses the rest of the sale. Price negotiation gets faster. Objections get smaller. The customer wants the deal to work.
- Lost likability is permanent. The city dealer was on Corie's no-buy list forever, even at any discount. One bad interaction killed a lifetime of potential sales.
- Likability is the only lever where every unit invested compounds for years. Time, money, and effort spent here pay dividends far beyond the immediate deal.

"When you're likable enough, you're not selling anymore. They're buying. And they will defend their decision to buy from you against cheaper alternatives, because they don't want to lose YOU — not the deal." — Corie (paraphrased)

12. Behaviours to change this week

6. **Aim for 80/20 — likability before technique.** On every call, prioritise the connection over the product spec. Technique only works if likability is already in place.
7. **Digest after every session.** Spend 4× the lesson time turning it over. If you can't explain yesterday's concept to a colleague today, you didn't digest it.
8. **Vet the three locks in this order.** Affordability (research before the call). Intent (the scale-up / wind-down question early in the meeting). Likability (the entire rest of the call).
9. **Replace symmetric bets with asymmetric ones.** "That must be a hard job" instead of "I bet teaching's easy these days." Asymmetric language builds either way.
10. **Avoid the three landmines.** Religion, politics, personal finance. No upside. Catastrophic downside. Don't even joke around them.
11. **Use at least one pattern interrupt per pitch.** End early. Refuse the close. Name the awkward thing first. Whatever it is — break the script the prospect was expecting.
12. **Run the long-relationship audit.** Pick your three longest-tenured clients. Are you treating them with first-date care, or with 18-month-mortgage complacency? Refresh the care this week.
13. **Recognise "the speech" and let it land gracefully.** Don't fight a polite no from a likable-but-broken deal. Bank the likability for next year. Move on.

Final reminder. Three lock pins. The first two are out of your control once the meeting starts. The third is the one you can actually move. Spend your energy there. Get likable. The deals will follow — and the ones that don't close today will sit in your pipeline as warm relationships for years.